

victory. Instead, he is stepping on the accelerator. Ever since the DMK took the reins in the state in May 2006, the party has poached three MLAs and two MPs from the Opposition, not to speak of prize catches like T.M. Selvaganapathy and Anitha R. Radhakrishnan of the AIADMK. The top leadership of the MDMK was literally wiped out by the DMK

in a systematic hunting spree. The latest one to jump the fence was the MDMK's K.S. Radhakrishnan. MDMK chief Vaiko is a much mauled leader today.

Successive defeats have totally demoralised the Opposition. The AIADMK and MDMK boycotted the recent by-elections because they did not trust the Electronic Voting Machines

(EVMs). Going by the number of deserters and fence-sitters, there is little hope for the Opposition's immediate revival. Some DMK leaders even claim that there is no Opposition in Tamil Nadu. "In the last three years of the DMK Government, the leader of the main Opposition AIADMK, J. Jayalalithaa, has spent much of her time at a remote hill station bungalow. There is not a single significant protest against the ruling party. The benevolent rule of the *Thalaivar* (The Supreme Leader) Karunanidhi is going from strength to strength," says T.K.S. Elangovan, the party's organisation secretary and a Lok Sabha member. New populist measures like free medical insurance have made the regime politically stronger, though the state has a total deficit of Rs 11,825 crore with a revenue deficit of Rs 1,024 crore.

Dravidian politicians are great illusionists. The illusion Karunanidhi wants to create now is of a formidable DMK with popular support and a weak Opposition. Continuing the popular

S TRENGTH

At 86 and wheel-chair bound, Karunanidhi is still one step ahead of his opponents. He effectively uses his oratory and writing skills to mesmerise the cadre amid distractions like family squabbles.

W EAKNESS

As the grand patriarch of the south's biggest political dynasty, he has to keep so many family members happy as their demands and political aspirations keep growing.

O PPORTUNITY

Amma in hibernation. Jayalalithaa has failed to be a combative counterpoint to her traditional antagonist. She even boycotted the recent by-elections on the pretext of not trusting the EVMs.

T HREAT

The so-called Black MGR. Desperate foes of the DMK leader might try to form a front with film star Vijayakanth as a charismatic vote-catcher. And the arrogance of power is on the rise.

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